Conservation funding for the underground irrigation conversion

Researched 2026-08-24. Supersedes the rough notes in `conservation-grants.txt` (kept for reference). **Correction to those notes: COID itself does not appear to run a patron grant program** — COID's money goes into its own large-scale canal piping (e.g. the $25M federally funded Pilot Butte Canal project). What COID offers landowners directly is a **low-interest loan program** ($400K over two years) and partnership in the county on-farm program below. The actual on-farm *grants* come from DSWCD/DRC, NRCS, and Energy Trust.

Best fit first: Deschutes County On-Farm Efficiency Water Conservation Investment

Partnership of **Deschutes SWCD + Deschutes River Conservancy (DRC) + COID**, originally seeded with **$1.45M of county ARPA funds**.

- **What it funds:** piping private laterals, upgrading on-farm efficiency infrastructure, flood→sprinkler conversion, "or other water conservation savings activities" — the underground-PVC conversion fits squarely.
- **Terms:** up to **$15,000 per landowner**, **1:1 cost-share** (you match).
- Leverages **$400,000 of COID investment** in a **low-interest loan program** for landowners — useful for the portion above the grant cap.
- 20% of funding is set aside for irrigators across Deschutes County and other irrigation districts.
- **Contacts:**
  - Erin Kilcullen (DSWCD) — Ekilcullen.dswcd@outlook.com
  - Kate Fitzpatrick (DRC) — kate@deschutesriver.org
  - Baxter Davies (COID) — bdavies@coid.org — **541-550-6834**
- ⚠️ Program status/remaining funds **not confirmed** (ARPA-seeded, 2021 vintage) — ask whether it's still funded for 2026 when calling.

NRCS EQIP — Deschutes County On-farm Irrigation and Energy Efficiency

USDA NRCS runs a **Deschutes-County-specific** EQIP initiative for on-farm irrigation + energy efficiency (sprinkler irrigation and energy efficiency improvements are explicitly in its prioritization questions).

- 🗒️ **Deadline status — CORRECTED 2026-08-24.** The widely-cited **January 15, 2026** national batching date was the **FY2026** round, which has already **passed** (today is Aug 2026 — I initially quoted it as if upcoming; that was wrong). Applications are accepted continuously, so applying

now lands in the **FY2027** cycle. If NRCS keeps the same pattern the next batching date would be ~**January 15, 2027**, but **do not rely on that** — confirm the current ranking date with the Redmond/Deschutes field office. Competitive: popular practices can exhaust funding within a cycle, so earlier in the cycle is better.

- ✅ **ELIGIBILITY — CONFIRMED GOOD.** Casey raises **meat cattle and files a Schedule F**, so he is a bona fide agricultural producer, which is what EQIP requires. Bonus: the irrigation waters *livestock pasture*, a well-established EQIP resource concern (irrigation efficiency on pastureland) — a much stronger case than a landscaping/hobby framing.
- **Prerequisite: an FSA farm number** is required *before* applying. If we don't have one, contact the local **FSA** office early — this is the long pole for hitting Jan 15.
- **Forms** (the local planner walks you through these): CPA-1200 (application), AD-2047 (customer data), CCC-941 (AGI), AD-1026 (HEL/ wetland), CCC-902 (farm operating plan), CCC-860 if claiming beginning/veteran/limited-resource/socially-disadvantaged status (those categories get higher payment rates).
- Process: local NRCS **conservation planner visits the property**, walks it with you, then writes a conservation plan of practices addressing the resource concerns — that plan is what gets funded.
- Relevant practice codes to ask about: **430 Irrigation Pipeline**, **442 Sprinkler System**, plus pumping-plant/energy practices. Oregon publishes a **payment schedule** with per-unit rates (per foot, per acre); ask the planner for the FY2026 Oregon schedule for these codes.
- Next step: contact the **Redmond/Deschutes County NRCS field office** — free site visit, confirm Oregon's ranking date vs. the Jan 15 national date, and get the payment-schedule rates.

Energy Trust of Oregon — equipment incentives (not a grant, but stackable)

Confirmed **2026 incentives are active**. Relevant to this project:

- **Sprinklers, nozzles and gaskets** — cash incentives (our aluminum latch pipe leaks at gaskets; new heads/nozzles qualify).
- **Irrigation system conversions** — e.g. **$500/acre** for hand line / solid set / traveler → **drip**.
- **Irrigation pump VFD** — incentives for VFDs on existing pumps **up to 100 HP** (new retrofit option) and new pumps up to 22.5 HP. *A VFD on the 5 HP pump is worth pricing — it would also solve the recycle/pressure problem in hardware.*
- **Sprinkler package upgrades** (LESA, LEPA, MESA, PMDI) — pivot-oriented, probably N/A here.
- **Eligibility:** Energy Trust serves customers of **Portland General, Pacific Power, NW Natural, Cascade Natural Gas** — confirm the pump's utility qualifies.
- ⚠️ **Do not buy equipment before checking pre-approval requirements** — most incentive programs require application *before* purchase/install.

Recommended sequence

0. ⏰ **EQIP timing:** the FY2026 round already closed (Jan 15, 2026), so an application now targets **FY2027** — likely batching ~Jan 2027, to be confirmed with the field office. That's actually good news: there's time to do the site visit and conservation plan properly rather than rushing. Still start early — the plan + FSA farm number take time, and funding is competitive within a cycle.
1. **Call COID first: 541-548-6047** (or Baxter Davies, 541-550-6834). Ask (a) is the county on-farm efficiency cost-share still funded for 2026, (b) is this property on a lateral scheduled for district piping — that often unlocks dedicated funding, (c) the low-interest loan terms.
2. **Contact Redmond/Deschutes NRCS field office** — free site visit, EQIP eligibility check, and the 2026 ranking date.
3. **Check Energy Trust pre-approval** before purchasing any pipe/heads/VFD.
4. Stack where allowed: EQIP or county cost-share for the piping + Energy Trust for equipment + COID loan for the remainder.

Evidence we already have for an application

- Measured per-line flows and pressures (`TODO.md`) — ~99 GPM on line 4, mainline loss 3.8 psi, lateral loss 1.2 psi.
- Gasket leakage in aluminum latch pipe is real and measurable — the direct water-loss argument for glued PVC.
- 3 years of pump energy data (~113 kWh/day in season, ~$1,559/season at 8.66 ¢/kWh) — the energy-savings side.
- Target: **~½ the water** after conversion (`docs/fields.md`).
- Timeliness: **COID cutting deliveries to ~60%** in 2026 — conservation is exactly what the district wants to fund.
- **Agricultural standing: meat cattle, Schedule F filer** — establishes producer eligibility and frames the project as irrigation efficiency on livestock pasture.